



THE TROJANS

Artists from the Royal Opera, with Eva-Maria Westbroek as Dido (center), perform Berlioz's five-act epic opera *The Trojans*, directed by David McVicar and conducted by Antonio Pappano at the Royal Opera House, London, in 2013.

Challenges and reputation

Berlioz also received a state commission for his *Requiem* (1837), which commemorates victims of the 1830 Revolution. This was a vast undertaking, involving more than 400 performers. A tremendous success, it was always cited by the composer as the achievement of which he was most proud.

The fate of Berlioz's first opera, *Benvenuto Cellini* (1838), was rather less auspicious. The first night was a disaster and it closed after four performances. Critics have praised the verve and imagination of some sections, but the composer's ambition undermined the overall effect. Berlioz was intent on cramming in so much variety, which was often delivered at a frenetic pace and demanded such virtuosity from his musicians, that the opera was not only technically difficult to